

React + GitHub Copilot Workshop — Pre-Event Setup Guide

Please do this before you come to the workshop. If you get stuck on anything, just message in the group and we'll sort it out. Coming without a working setup means you'll miss the first 30 minutes — so please don't skip this!

Section 1 — Install VS Code

Windows — pick whichever option is easier for you:

- **Option A (website):** Go to <https://code.visualstudio.com> → Download → run the installer. When you hit the "Select Additional Tasks" screen, tick all of these:
 - ☒ Add "Open with Code" to Windows Explorer file context menu
 - ☒ Add "Open with Code" to Windows Explorer directory context menu
 - ☒ Register Code as an editor for supported file types
 - ☒ Add to PATH
- **Option B (Microsoft Store):** Open the Microsoft Store on your PC → search **Visual Studio Code** → Install. Easier, no setup needed, updates itself.

macOS — go to <https://code.visualstudio.com> → download the .zip → drag VS Code into your Applications folder. If your Mac blocks it, go to System Preferences → Security & Privacy → Open Anyway.

Section 2 — Create a GitHub Account

1. Go to <https://github.com/signup?source=login>
2. Use any email — personal or university, doesn't matter
3. Pick a password and username
4. Do the verification puzzle → **Create account**
5. Check your inbox and click **Verify email address**

Add your university email (you'll need this for the Student Pack)

1. Go to <https://github.com/settings/emails>
2. Add your @utp.edu.my email and click **Add**
3. Verify it from your uni inbox

Already signed up with your uni email? Skip this.

Section 3 — Apply for the GitHub Student Developer Pack

The Student Pack gets you **GitHub Copilot for free** (it normally costs \$10/month). Approval usually takes a few hours — sometimes it's instant if GitHub recognises your uni email.

How to apply

1. Go to <https://education.github.com/pack>
2. Click **Sign up for Student Developer Pack**
3. Select **Student**
4. Enter your school: **Universiti Teknologi PETRONAS**
5. Enter your @utp.edu.my email (the one you added in Section 2)
6. For "How do you plan to use GitHub?" just write something honest, like:

"I'm a CS student learning React and web development. I'll use GitHub Copilot to help with my coursework."

7. Upload your **offer letter** (clear photo or scan, JPG or PNG, under 1MB) → **Submit**

⚠ **Still waiting on workshop day?** No worries — just start the 30-day free trial in Section 4.

Section 4 — Enable GitHub Copilot

If your Student Pack got approved

1. Go to <https://github.com/settings/copilot>
2. Click **Enable GitHub Copilot** → Save

If it's still pending

1. Go to <https://github.com/settings/copilot>
2. Click **Start free trial** — it's 30 days, you won't be charged during the workshop
3. You'll need to add a payment method, but nothing gets charged until the trial ends
4. Just cancel it after if you don't want to keep it

Check it's working

Go to <https://github.com/settings/copilot> — it should say "**GitHub Copilot is active**" 

Section 5 — Install GitHub Copilot in VS Code

1. Open Extensions in VS Code (Ctrl+Shift+X on Windows / Cmd+Shift+X on Mac)
2. Search **GitHub Copilot** → install the one by **GitHub** (not a third-party one)
3. A popup will ask you to sign in to GitHub — click it
4. It'll open your browser to confirm — authorize it, then come back to VS Code

5. You should see "**GitHub Copilot is now active**" 

No popup? Click the account icon at the bottom left of VS Code → **Sign in with GitHub to use GitHub Copilot**

Quick test to make sure it works

1. Ctrl+N / Cmd+N to open a new file
2. Ctrl+Shift+P → type **Change Language Mode** → select **JavaScript**
3. On line 1, type:
4. *// function to add two numbers*
5. Hit Enter and wait a second or two
6. Copilot should show a faded suggestion — press **Tab** to accept it 

Section 6 — Install Node.js

1. Go to <https://nodejs.org>
2. Download the **LTS** version (not Current)
3. Run the installer — just keep clicking Next, all the defaults are fine

Check it installed properly

Open **Command Prompt** (Windows: Win key → type "cmd") or **Terminal** (Mac: Cmd+Space → type "terminal") and run:

```
node -v
```

You should see something like v20.x.x or v22.x.x 

```
npm -v
```

Should be 8.x or higher 

Getting an error? Close the terminal, open a new one, and try again.

Section 7 — Test Your React Setup

Open the terminal inside VS Code: Ctrl+` or go to **Terminal → New Terminal**

Run these one by one — wait for each to finish before running the next:

```
npm create vite@latest test-project -- --template react
```

If it asks to install create-vite, type y and hit Enter.

```
cd test-project
```

```
npm install
```

This one takes a minute or two. Wait until you see added X packages.

npm run dev

Now open your browser and go to <http://localhost:5173>

If you see the Vite + React page with a counter — you're all set 

When you're done, click the terminal and press Ctrl+C to stop the server. You can delete the test-project folder, it was just for testing.

Section 8 — Troubleshooting

node is not recognised / command not found

Windows:

1. Close Command Prompt and open a fresh one
2. Try node -v again
3. Still not working? Search "Environment Variables" in Windows → Edit System Environment Variables → look for **Path** under System Variables → make sure C:\Program Files\nodejs\ is in there
4. If it's missing, uninstall Node.js and reinstall it — make sure "Add to PATH" is ticked

macOS:

1. Close Terminal and reopen it
2. Try node -v again
3. If that doesn't work, try /usr/local/bin/node -v — if that works, your PATH just needs updating

npm is not recognised

1. Uninstall Node.js
2. Reinstall from nodejs.org (grab the LTS version)
3. Restart your computer after installing

Copilot isn't showing suggestions

1. Check github.com/settings/copilot — it needs to say "Active"
2. Make sure you're signed into VS Code (account icon, bottom left)
3. Check the GitHub Copilot extension is actually installed
4. Hover over the Copilot icon (bottom right of VS Code) to see what it says

5. Try: Ctrl+Shift+P → **Reload Window**
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VS Code extension won't install

1. Check your internet connection
 2. If you're on university WiFi, try switching to your phone's hotspot — uni networks sometimes block the extension marketplace
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Port 5173 already in use

Error: Port 5173 is already in use

1. Open Task Manager (Windows) or Activity Monitor (Mac) and quit any Node.js processes
 2. Try npm run dev again
 3. Or just run it on a different port: npm run dev -- --port 3000
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Windows permission error during npm install

1. Close VS Code
 2. Right-click VS Code → **Run as Administrator**
 3. Try npm install again
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npm install is hanging or showing network errors

Switch to your **phone's mobile hotspot** — university WiFi often blocks npm's servers.

Or try: npm install --registry <https://registry.npmjs.org>

Student Pack application got rejected

- **Document isn't clear enough** — retake the photo in good lighting, make sure all text is readable
- **Email doesn't match** — the email on your document needs to match what you submitted
- **University not recognised** — try just submitting with your uni email, sometimes GitHub verifies by domain and you skip the document upload altogether

You can resubmit straight away after a rejection.

Still stuck?

Message the workshop group with:

1. A screenshot of what you're seeing
2. Your OS (Windows 10/11, or which macOS version)
3. Which step you're on

We'll help you get sorted before the workshop.